Alfonso mangoes, renowned for their fragrant flesh and creamy texture, have a short season in India from early April through May. Other varieties work well too.

mango and curry leaf soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 1 MONTH
AT THE END OF STEP 3

for the garnish
small handful of curry leaves
vegetable oil for deep frying

for the soup
4 ripe mangoes, Alfonso if in season, available from South Asian stores
2 tbsp vegetable oil
1 tsp black mustard seeds
handful of fresh curry leaves
1 red chile, seeded, finely chopped
2 tsp palm sugar or dark brown (muscovado) sugar
½ tsp turmeric
2 tsp rice flour
1¼–1¾ cups vegetable stock
1¼ cup coconut milk
juice of 1 lime, to taste
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp chopped fresh cilantro

1 First make the garnish: deep-fry the curry leaves in hot oil until crisp—it only takes a few seconds. Drain on paper towels and set aside.

2 Coarsely chop the flesh of 3 mangoes into small pieces and finely dice the fourth. Set aside. Heat the oil in a medium pan and, when hot, fry the mustard seeds for a few seconds before adding the curry leaves and chile. Continue frying for 30 seconds, until the leaves stop sputtering.

3 Add the 3 chopped mangoes to the pan, reserving the diced mango. Turn the heat to low and simmer the fruit until softened. Stir in the sugar and cook until the mango begins to caramelize. Sprinkle over the turmeric and rice flour and cook for 30 seconds, stirring all the time. Pour over 1¼ cups of the stock and simmer for 10 minutes.

4 Add the coconut milk and simmer for 2–3 minutes. Sharpen with lime juice, season with salt and pepper, and stir in the cilantro and diced mango. If the soup is too thick, add a little hot vegetable stock. Divide the soup between the bowls and sprinkle with a few crisp-fried curry leaves.